

Lecture Notes for Math 243: Calculus III

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0 Tentative Course Outline

- **Weeks 1-3:** Parametric equations and Polar coordinates
 1. Arc length
 2. Curves defined by parametric equations.
 3. Calculus with plane curves.
 4. Polar coordinates
 5. Areas and lengths in polar coordinates
 6. Conic sections.
- **Weeks 4-6:** Vectors and the geometry of space.
 1. Three-dimensional coordinate systems.
 2. Vectors.
 3. The dot product.
 4. The cross product.
 5. Equations of lines and planes.
 6. Cylinders and quadric surfaces.
- **Friday, October 16 (week 8):** Midterm exam
- **Weeks 7-9:** Vector functions.
 1. Vector functions and space curves
 2. Derivatives and integrals of vector functions.
 3. Arc length and curvature.
 4. Motion in space: velocity and acceleration.
- **Weeks 10-16:** Partial derivatives.
 1. Functions of several variables.
 2. Limits and continuity
 3. Partial derivatives.
 4. Tangent planes and linear approximations
 5. The chain rule.
 6. Directional derivatives and the gradient vector.
 7. Maximum and minimum values.
 8. Discovery project (p.1010 Stewart): Quadratic approximation and critical points (Taylors formula for two variables).
 9. Lagrange multipliers.
- **Monday, December 14:** Final exam.

1 2026-08-24 | Week 01 | Lecture 01

This lecture is based on textbook section 6.3. “Arc length”

The nexus question of this lecture: How do we compute the length of a curve, assuming the curve is the graph of a function?

1.1 Arc Length

First, recall the definition of **derivative**:

$$f'(x) := \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h}$$

or equivalently,

$$f'(x) = \lim_{\tilde{x} \rightarrow x} \frac{f(\tilde{x}) - f(x)}{\tilde{x} - x}$$

In other words, the derivative is obtained by computing

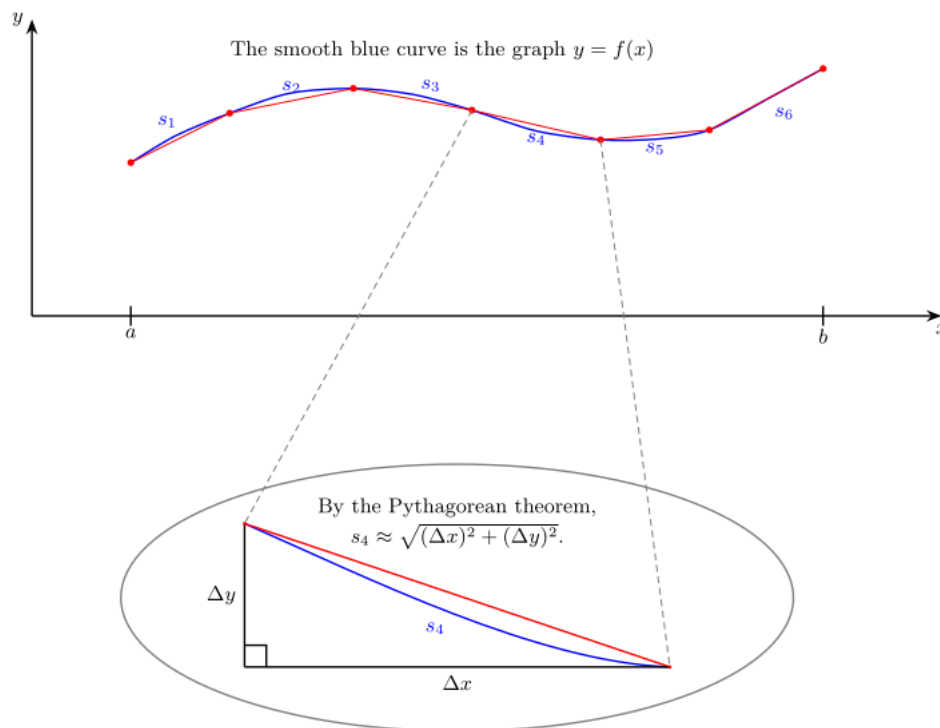
$$\frac{\text{change in } y\text{-value}}{\text{change in } x\text{-value}} = \frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}$$

as $\Delta x \rightarrow 0$.

One of the central ideas in calculus is to approximate curvy things with flat things. For example, if faced with a curve, approximate it with straight lines. For example,

Problem: I am an ant, and I want to travel from a to b by walking on the graph of $f(x)$. How far must I walk?

Strategy: Cheat a little: think of the ant walking in a bunch of straight lines that are pretty close to the curve.



In this example, the length of the curve $y = f(x)$ from $x = a$ to $x = b$ can be decomposed as

$$(\text{Arc Length}) = s_1 + s_2 + \dots + s_6,$$

where

$$s_i = (\text{length of segment } i)$$

Each segment length can be approximated by a straight line. For example,

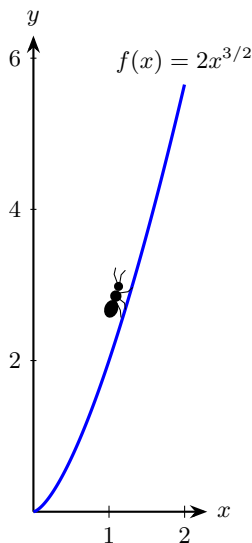
$$\begin{aligned} s_4 &\approx \sqrt{(\Delta x)^2 + (\Delta y)^2} && \text{since the line segment length approximates the curve length} \\ &= \sqrt{\left[1 + \left(\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}\right)^2\right] (\Delta x)^2} \\ &= \sqrt{1 + \left(\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}\right)^2} \Delta x \\ &\approx \sqrt{1 + \left(\frac{dy}{dx}\right)^2} dx && \text{this holds when } \Delta x \approx 0, \text{ so long as the curve is smooth} \\ &= \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2} dx && \text{by change of notation} \end{aligned}$$

This example motivates the following theorem.

Theorem 1 (Arc length formula). *Let f be a differentiable function on the interval $[a, b]$, and assume that f' is continuous on $[a, b]$. Then the arc length of f from $x = a$ to $x = b$ is*

$$(\text{Arc Length}) = \int_a^b \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2} dx$$

Example 2 (Arc length). Find the length of the curve defined by $f(x) = 2x^{3/2}$, where x ranges from $x = 0$ to $x = 2$.



Solution: $f'(x) = 3x^{\frac{1}{2}}$, so

$$\begin{aligned} (\text{Arc length}) &= \int_0^2 \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2} dx \\ &= \int_0^2 \sqrt{1 + 9x} dx \end{aligned}$$

which we can solve with a u -substitution, taking $u = 1 + 9x$. Doing this gives a length of about 6.06.

End of Example 2. $\square$

The **hyperbolic cosine** and **hyperbolic sine** functions are defined as

$$\cosh(x) := \frac{e^x + e^{-x}}{2}, \quad \sinh(x) := \frac{e^x - e^{-x}}{2}.$$

These two functions are “nice” in that they behave in some respects similarly to the standard sine and cosine functions; in particular, $\cosh$ is an even function (like $\cos(x)$) and $\sinh(x)$ is odd (like $\sin(x)$).

One can check they satisfy:

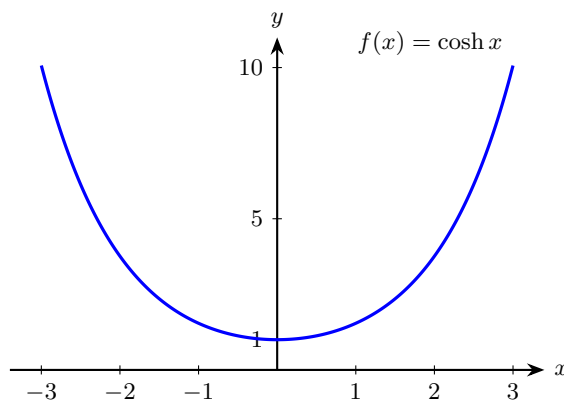
$$\cosh'(x) = \sinh(x), \quad \sinh'(x) = \cosh(x). \quad (1)$$

Also, we have the following identity:

$$\cosh^2(x) - \sinh^2(x) = 1. \quad (2)$$

A hanging chain forms a curve known as a **catenary**. The general formula of a catenary is a function involving hyperbolic cosine; in the next example, we'll consider the simplest case.

Example 3 (Arc length). Suppose $f(x) = \cosh(x)$ represents a chain from two endpoints at $x = -3$ and $x = 3$. Find the length of the chain.



$$\begin{aligned} \text{(length of chain)} &= \int_{-3}^3 \sqrt{1 + [\cosh'(x)]^2} dx \\ &= \int_{-3}^3 \sqrt{1 + \sinh^2(x)} dx && \text{since } \cosh'(x) = \sinh(x) \text{ by Eq. (1)} \\ &= \int_{-3}^3 \sqrt{\cosh^2(x)} dx && \text{by Eq. (2)} \\ &= \int_{-3}^3 \cosh(x) dx && \text{since } \cosh(x) > 0 \text{ for all } x \in \mathbb{R} \\ &= [\sinh(x)]_{x=-3}^{x=3} && \text{since } \sinh'(x) = \cosh(x) \text{ Eq. (1)} \\ &= \sinh(3) - \sinh(-3) \\ &\approx 20.036 \end{aligned}$$

End of Example 3. $\square$

Tips

- Check that your answer is positive. Arc length is never negative.
- These problems are usually contrived so that you can actually do the integral. If the integral looks too hard, double check your work. Also, there might be a trick to the integral.

2 2026-08-26 | Week 01 | Lecture 02

This lecture is based on textbook section 6.3 “Arc Length”, and section 11.1 “Parametric Equations and Polar Coordinates”. Please read 6.3 and begin start reading 11.1.

Example 4 (Warm up problem: Chain rule practice). Find the derviative of

$$f(x) = \log\left(\frac{x^2}{\sin x}\right).$$

Solution:

$$\begin{aligned} f'(x) &= \frac{d}{dx} \left[\log\left(\frac{x^2}{\sin x}\right) \right] \\ &= \frac{\sin x}{x^2} \frac{d}{dx} \left[\frac{x^2}{\sin x} \right] && \text{by the chain rule} \\ &= \frac{\sin x}{x^2} \left(\frac{2x \sin x - x^2 \cos x}{(\sin x)^2} \right) && \text{by the quotient rule} \\ &= \frac{2}{x} - \cot x && \text{after simplification.} \end{aligned}$$

End of Example 4. $\square$

2.1 Arc length - examples

Example 5 (Arc length). **Problem:** Let

$$f(x) = \frac{x^3}{3} + \frac{1}{4x} + 7,$$

for $1 \leq x \leq 2$. earlier examples.

Solution: We want to apply Theorem 1. To do this, we first compute $1 + [f'(x)]^2$:

$$\begin{aligned} 1 + [f'(x)]^2 &= 1 + \left(x^2 - \frac{1}{4}x^{-2} \right)^2 \\ &= x^4 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{16}x^{-4} \\ &= \left(x^2 + \frac{1}{4}x^{-2} \right)^2. \end{aligned}$$

The last step, where we write the equation as a perfect square, is kinda hard to see. But since we're familiar with Example 3, we know to possibly expect something like that.

Now, we can apply the formula from Theorem 1:

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{Arc Length} &= \int_1^2 \sqrt{1 + [f'(x)]^2} dx \\
 &= \int_1^2 \sqrt{\left(x^2 + \frac{1}{4}x^{-2}\right)^2} dx \\
 &= \int_1^2 x^2 + \frac{1}{4}x^{-2} dx \\
 &= \left[\frac{x^3}{3} - \frac{1}{4}x^{-1}\right]_1^2 \\
 &= \left(\frac{8}{3} - \frac{1}{8}\right) - \left(\frac{1}{3} - \frac{1}{4}\right) \\
 &\approx 2.46.
 \end{aligned}$$

End of Example 5. $\square$

Example 6. Find the arc length of

$$f(x) = \frac{x^3}{12} + x^{-1}, \quad 1 \leq x \leq 4$$

Solution: For the complete solution, see Example 2 in section 6.3 of the textbook. We sketch the approach here.

The key step is to factor

$$\begin{aligned}
 1 + [f'(x)]^2 &= \frac{x^4}{16} + \frac{1}{2} + x^{-4} \\
 &= \left(\frac{x^2}{4} + x^{-2}\right)^2
 \end{aligned}$$

The arc length integral then reduces to

$$\int_1^4 \left(\frac{x^2}{4} + x^{-2}\right) dx$$

which evaluates to 6.

End of Example 6. $\square$

2.2 Introduction to parametric equations

This section is based on chapter 11.1 in the textbook.

I am an ant walking around the whiteboard, and I'm covered in ink. My path is described in the following way:

- The variable t measures time. We start at $t = 0$ and end at time $t = T_{\text{end}} > 0$.
- At each moment in time t , the number $x(t)$ represents my x -coordinate
- And the number $y(t)$ represents my y -coordinate.

The **parametric equation** is the picture I draw by walking around the whiteboard.

Definition 7 (Parametric Equations and Curves). Suppose x and y are given as functions

$$x = f(t), \quad y = g(t)$$

over an interval of t -values I . Then as t varies over I , the set of all points of the form

$$(x, y) = (f(t), g(t)), \quad (3)$$

as t varies over I , is called a **parametric curve**. The equations in Eq. (3) are called the **parametric equations** of the curve.

The variable t is called the **parameter**. If $I = [a, b]$, then the **initial point** is $(f(a), g(a))$ and the **terminal point** is $(f(b), g(b))$.

Notation 8. In “set-builder notation,” the graph of the parametric equations $x = f(t)$ and $y = g(t)$ is the set

$$\{(f(t), g(t)) : t \in I\}.$$

For those unfamiliar with this notation: the colon ‘:’ is read as “such that” and ‘ $\in$ ’ is an abbreviation of “is an element of”

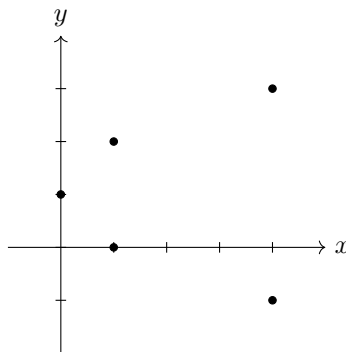
Example 9 (Plotting parametric functions). Plot the graph of the parametric equations

$$\begin{cases} x = t^2 \\ y = t + 1 \end{cases}$$

for t in $I = [-2, 2]$.

Solution: Start by plotting some points by making a table.

t	$x = t^2$	$y = t + 1$
-2	4	-1
-1	1	0
0	0	1
1	1	2
2	4	3



Once we get a sense of what the curve looks like, we can draw a curve through the points.

- If we replace $I = [-2, 2]$ by $I = \mathbb{R}$, then this corresponding graph would trace out a sideways opening parabola defined by the equation $x = (y - 1)^2$.

Question: can we write y a function of x ?

Answer: No, because the graph doesn’t satisfy the vertical line test.

Question: can we express this as an equation involving only x and y ?

Answer: yes, the parabola is $x = (y - 1)^2$, so the parametric curve is can be written as

$$x = (y - 1)^2, \quad 0 \leq x \leq 4.$$

End of Example 9. $\square$

3 2026-08-28 | Week 01 | Lecture 03

This lecture is based on section 11.1 in the textbook

Reading assignment: Section 11.1 in the text book.

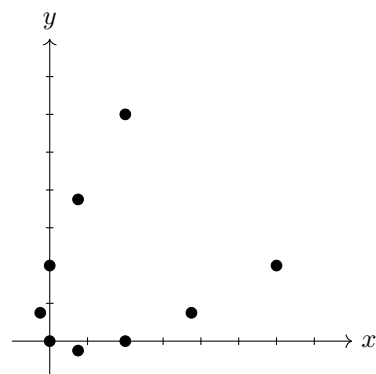
3.1 Plotting parametric equations

Example 10. *Question:* Plot the graph of the parametric equation

$$r(t) = (t^2 + t, t^2 - t), \quad -2 \leq t \leq 2$$

Solution: Again, we plot some points by making a table.

t	$x = t^2 + t$	$y = t^2 - t$
-2	2	6
$-\frac{3}{2}$	.75	3.75
-1	0	2
$-\frac{1}{2}$	$-\frac{1}{4}$	$\frac{3}{4}$
0	0	0
$\frac{1}{2}$	$\frac{3}{4}$	$-\frac{1}{4}$
1	2	0
$\frac{3}{2}$	3.75	$\frac{3}{4}$
2	6	2



The graph of the parametric equations is obtained by drawing the curve through the plotted points.

End of Example 10. $\square$

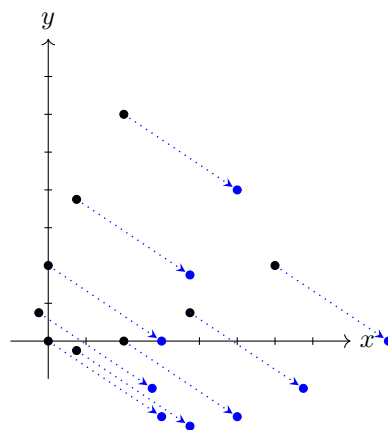
Example 11. Find the parametric equations that shift the graph from Example 10 to the right by 3 and down by 2.

Solution: The graphs of parametric equations are easy to shift. The parametric equations defining the shifted graph are

$$r(t) = (t^2 + t + 3, t^2 - t - 2)$$

We've simply added 3 to the x -value and subtracted 2 from the y -value. To see why this is the case, observe what happens to the points in the plot from Example 10:

t	$x = t^2 + t + 3$	$y = t^2 - t - 2$
-2	2+3	6-2
$-\frac{3}{2}$	.75+3	3.75-2
-1	0+3	2-2
$-\frac{1}{2}$	$-\frac{1}{4}+3$	$\frac{3}{4}-2$
0	0+3	0-2
$\frac{1}{2}$	$\frac{3}{4}+3$	$-\frac{1}{4}-2$
1	2+3	0-2
$\frac{3}{2}$	3.75+3	$\frac{3}{4}-2$
2	6+3	2-2



Here we have shifted every point to the right by 3 and down by 2, as shown by the arrows. Drawing a curve through the blue points now gives us the curve of the new, shifted, parametric equations. (Not shown in figure).

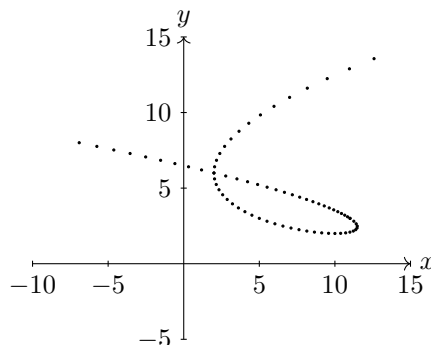
End of Example 11. $\square$

Parametric functions have the advantage that we can use them to plot curves which cannot be plotted by “ $y = f(x)$ ” type graphs.

Example 12. Here’s an example of a plot of the parametric curve

$$r(t) = \begin{pmatrix} x \\ y \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} t^3 - 5t^2 + 3t + 11 \\ t^2 - 2t + 3 \end{pmatrix}$$

This one would be tedious to plot by hand, so instead I plotted a bunch of points with a computer, with t varying on the interval $I = [-1.5, 4.5]$.



The parametric equation can be thought of as tracing the trajectory of a particle as it moves over time. In this example, t represents time. At time $t = -1.5$, the particle is at point $(x, y) = (-8.125, 8.25)$, and starts heading southeast. It then turns around and loops over its previous path, before heading northeast.

It would be impossible to represent this trajectory using a function $y = f(x)$, because the curve fails the vertical line test. This is one advantage of parametric curves.

The particle has the same position at times $t = -1$ and $t = 3$. At these times, the particle is at the point

$$(x, y) = (2, 6).$$

Thus, it is at this point that the curve intersects itself, a phenomenon known as a **singularity**.

End of Example 12. $\square$

3.2 Converting between parametric equations and Cartesian equations

In contrast to parametric equations, an equation is said to be in **rectangular form** (aka: **Cartesian form**) if it takes the form $y = f(x)$ (or, less commonly, $x = f(y)$) for some function f . We’ve just seen in Example 12 that parametric equations offer significantly more flexibility when graphing.

In fact, it is always possible to convert an equation from rectangular form into parametric form. We illustrate this with the next example:

Example 13 (Converting from rectangular form to parametric form). Consider the equation $y = x^2$, which is in rectangular form. This is an upward-opening parabola. There are many ways to represent this in parametric form. The simplest is with the parametric equations

$$r(t) = (t, t^2), \quad -\infty < t < \infty.$$

End of Example 13. $\square$

Example 14 (Converting from parametric form to rectangular form). Sometimes (but not always) we can also convert from parametric to rectangular form. Consider the parametric equations

$$\begin{cases} x = t^2 \\ y = 7 + 5t \end{cases}$$

This is done by “eliminating” the parameter t , in the following way:

Since $y = 7 + 5t$, it follows that

$$t = \frac{y - 7}{5}.$$

Plugging this into $x = t^2$ gives

$$\begin{aligned} x &= \left(\frac{y - 7}{5} \right)^2 \\ &= \frac{1}{25} (y^2 - 14y + 49) \\ &= \frac{1}{25} y^2 - \frac{14}{25} y + \frac{49}{25}. \end{aligned}$$

This equation has the form $x = f(y)$, and therefore is in rectangular (i.e., Cartesian) form.

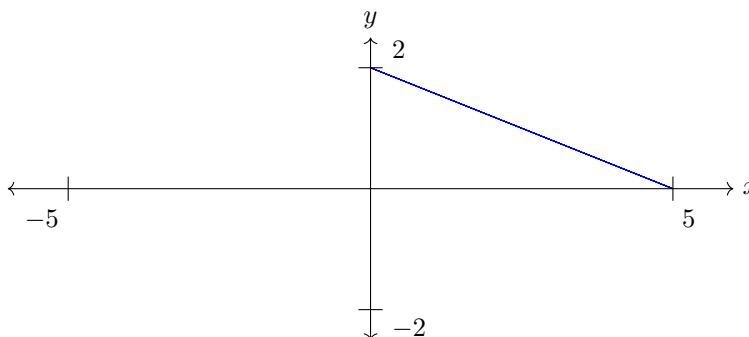
End of Example 14. $\square$

Here’s another example

Example 15 (Converting to Cartesian form: eliminating a parameter). Consider the parametric equations

$$\begin{cases} x = 5 \cos^2(\theta) \\ y = 2 \sin^2(\theta) \end{cases}, \quad 0 \leq \theta \leq 2\pi.$$

I plotted this using a computer and got the following. It is a line segment:



Question: Convert these parametric equations into Cartesian form, ie a function of the form $y = f(x)$.

Solution: Before we start, recall the identity $\sin^2(\theta) + \cos^2(\theta) = 1$ for all θ . using this, we have:

$$\begin{aligned} y &= 2 \sin^2(\theta) \\ &= 2 (1 - \cos^2(\theta)) \end{aligned}$$

Now, $x = 5 \cos^2(\theta)$, so $\cos^2(\theta) = \frac{x}{5}$. Plugging this into the above equation gives:

$$y = 2 \left(1 - \frac{x}{5} \right).$$

This is an equation of a line.

But we are not done! We are trying to plot only a line *segment*, not the full line. So we need to specify that we are restricting the line to only those x in the interval $[0, 5]$. So our solution (in Cartesian form) is

$$\begin{cases} y = 2 \left(1 - \frac{x}{5} \right) \\ 0 \leq x \leq 5 \end{cases}$$

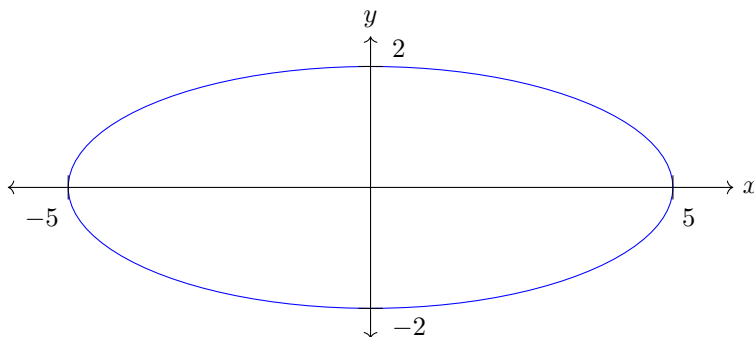
End of Example 15. $\square$

4 2026-08-31 | Week 02 | Lecture 04

Example 16 (An ellipse, parametrized). What if we slightly modify the equations from the Example 15? Consider the parametric equations

$$\begin{cases} x = 5 \cos(\theta) \\ y = 2 \sin(\theta) \end{cases}, \quad 0 \leq \theta \leq 2\pi$$

Here, the only difference from the equations in Example 15 is that we have removed the squares. Now we get a very different looking curve: an ellipse.



End of Example 16. $\square$